

INTERVIEW | V.K. SARASWAT

"Our empowerment comes with accountability"

DRDO Chief V. K. Saraswat spoke to Senior Editor SANDEEP UNNITHAN on why its proposed restructuring will transform the organisation to deliver on time.

Q. How will the DRDO now deliver to the services on time?

A. We are decentralising the organisation, creating technology-based clusters, headed by director-generals and empowering them with financial powers. With this empowerment will come accountability. We will try to deliver on time.

Q. The armed forces will import equipment worth \$100 billion. Is the restructuring a little too late?



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A. The process of weapon acquisition is complex. The process of development and acquisition is complex and painful. While the temptation to field proven state-of-the-art imported systems is great, the services too have a role to play in the economic and industrial growth of the country. I would request them to

ensure we should be importing that system for the first and last time.

Q. Why the collaboration with Israel for the Long-Range Surface-to-Air Missile (LR-SAM) when we have perfected the missile interceptor?

A. It is our strategy to collaborate to overcome the technology gap in an accelerated manner. We had a technology gap in homing and guidance system of the missile for which we went for a joint venture. The LR-SAM was successfully tested in Israel this month, the second test will be in India later this year. It will be delivered to the armed forces in 2013.

Q. The DRDO is not doing anything for the paramilitary forces fighting the Maoists.

A. Three months ago, we initiated a major programme with the Home Ministry to adapt our defence technologies for low intensity conflict. The thrust areas are: detection—radars to find buried mines and the ability to penetrate foliage and walls—surveillance, communication interception, and personal protection systems—body armour to protect the soldiers from sudden ambushes. These will be fielded in the next two years.

him, the new system will upgrade the DG to a chairman with seven DGs, each heading various departments like land systems and aeronautics, reporting to him. All the 51 laboratories will be distributed into functionality based clusters of Labs called 'centres' headed by DGs. For instance, the DG of land systems will be responsible for developing the army's Future Main Battle Tank and have all the laboratories associated with the project—the Vehicles Research Development Establishment and the Combat Vehicles Research

HOW THE REFORMS WILL

PROBLEMS

Does not deliver on time

Inability to deliver production models

Very high teeth-to-tail ratio, 50,000 personnel but only 5,000 scientists

Technology focused, not product focused

Does not work closely with the armed forces

Development Establishment—working with him. The DGs have been given autonomy, financial powers—the DRDO is working the quantum—and will be held accountable in case of delays. Several laboratories deemed non-core areas will be done away with—the Defence Research Laboratory which manufactures mosquito repellants and water purifiers will be merged with the Indian Council of Agricultural Research while the Defence Food Research Laboratory which manufactures pre-cooked meals will be integrated with the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research. The Arjun battle tank, the Akash missile and the Kaveri engine programmes have been given new lease of life.

One of the most important recommendations is the creation of a 17-member Defence Technology Commission (DTC) along the lines of the Atomic Energy Commission. It is to be headed by the defence minister and will comprise the three service chiefs and secretaries of space, atomic energy commission, defence and defence finance. Besides monitoring the functioning of the DRDO, the DTC will formulate the policy for enhancing self-reliance, identify the critical technologies for the DRDO to work on, set tar-